

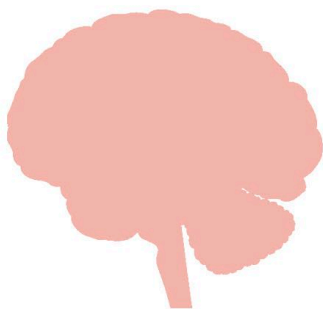
Q WILL ASANA PRACTICE REDUCE MY CHRONIC PAIN?

It depends. Some asanas can help reduce pain by stretching and strengthening the affected area(s). However, biomechanics is just one piece of the puzzle. At its most basic level, what your brain interprets as "pain" starts as a signal received from a receptor (nociceptor) in your body. Research has shown that the amount of pain perceived doesn't depend on the amount of tissue damage as seen in X-ray or MRI scans. This means that without the brain there is no pain; but this

doesn't mean pain is imagined. Your brain builds your pain experience just as it constructs your reality and perspective. The level of pain you experience is based on your brain's interpretation of the level of danger those signals represent. So, as with chronic stress, chronic pain is partly a problem with regulation, often related to a faulty alarm system. Research shows that relaxing yoga asanas and practices, such as meditation and pranayama, can help regulate the pain response.

Q HOW MUCH DO I NEED TO MEDITATE TO REDUCE PAIN?

Research has shown that less than 1½ hours of meditation training may help alleviate pain and diminish pain-related brain changes. One study showed that just four 20-minute mindfulness classes reduced the unpleasantness of pain by 57 percent and the intensity of pain by 40 percent. It wasn't just the perception of the pain that changed: the brain's activity also measurably changed. The same study showed, via fMRI scans, that meditation reduced pain-related activation of the primary somatosensory cortex. Instead of a spike of activity in the area of the somatosensory cortex related to the location of the pain, researchers found that, while meditating, participants had more brain activity reflecting sensory awareness of the neck and throat, which represented the participants' mindfulness of their breathing.



Did you know?

CHRONIC PAIN
CAUSES **GRAY MATTER
DETERIORATION,**
BUT THE AREAS OF
THE BRAIN THAT ARE
DEGRADED BY
CHRONIC PAIN ARE
**RESTORED DURING
MEDITATION** THROUGH
THE INCREASE OF
NEURAL CONNECTIONS
IN THOSE AREAS.

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Relaxing yoga asanas and practices, such as meditation and pranayama, can help regulate the pain response